



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 9.1: TARGETING CHORD TONES IN YOUR MELODIES

When crafting melodies, targeting chord tones is one of the most powerful tools in your arsenal. This approach ensures that your melodic lines feel connected to the harmony, creating a sense of resolution, tension, and musicality. In this lesson, we'll explore what chord tones are, why they're essential, and how to apply them effectively to elevate your playing.

WHAT ARE CHORD TONES?

Chord tones are the individual notes that make up a chord. For example, in a C major chord, the chord tones are:

- **Root (C)**
- **Third (E)**
- **Fifth (G)**

These tones form the foundation of the harmony and are naturally more stable and consonant than non-chord tones (e.g., passing tones or approach notes). Targeting these tones in your melodies creates a direct connection between your lead lines and the underlying chords.

WHY TARGET CHORD TONES?

1. **Enhances Musicality:** Melodies that emphasise chord tones sound purposeful and harmonically rich.
2. **Improves Improvisation:** Targeting chord tones during improvisation helps your lines stay grounded, even over complex progressions.
3. **Strengthens Composition:** Using chord tones in your songwriting ensures that your melodies complement the harmony effectively.

HOW TO IDENTIFY CHORD TONES ON THE FRETBOARD

1. **Visualising the Chord Shapes:** Begin by playing the chord shapes associated with the progression. Identify the root, third, and fifth within each shape. Practice this across different positions of the neck.
2. **Using Scales as a Guide:** Overlay the appropriate scale over the chord and identify which scale notes correspond to the chord tones. For instance, in a C major chord, the C major scale includes the chord tones (C, E, G) as key targets.



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3. **Practice Arpeggios:** Play the chord tones sequentially as arpeggios. This not only trains your fingers but also reinforces your ear to recognise these tones in a musical context.

TECHNIQUES FOR TARGETING CHORD TONES

1. Landing on Chord Tones:

- Aim to start or end your phrases on a chord tone. For example, if you're improvising over a C major chord, begin or resolve your line on C, E, or G.

2. Approach Notes:

- Use chromatic or diatonic approach notes to lead into a chord tone. For example:
 - Play **B** (chromatic) or **D** (diatonic) before landing on **C**.

3. Emphasising Specific Tones:

- Highlight different chord tones to evoke unique emotions:
 - The root provides stability.
 - The third adds emotional colour (major or minor).
 - The fifth reinforces the chord's strength.

4. Voice Leading:

- Create smooth transitions between chord tones in consecutive chords. For example:
 - Over C major to F major, move from **E** (third of C) to **F** (root of F).

Exercises

1. Identifying Chord Tones in Progressions:

- Write out the chord tones for a common progression like **C - Dm - Em - F**.
- Practise playing these tones on your fretboard.

2. Melodic Phrase Practice:

- Improvise over a backing track, ensuring every phrase begins or ends on a chord tone.

3. Approach Note Exercise:

- Practice approaching chord tones with chromatic and diatonic notes. For example, over a G chord, approach **B** (third) with **A#** (chromatic) or **A** (diatonic).



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4. Arpeggios and Scales:

- Combine arpeggios with scales, switching between the two to emphasise chord tones within a melodic context.

INTEGRATING CHORD TONE TARGETING INTO YOUR SOLOS

- **Start Simple:** Begin with basic progressions and focus on hitting the root notes of each chord.
- **Expand Gradually:** Incorporate thirds and fifths into your phrases as you become comfortable.
- **Experiment with Rhythm:** Play around with different rhythmic patterns to make your melodies more dynamic.
- **Blend Techniques:** Combine targeting chord tones with other melodic devices like slides, bends, and vibrato for expressive phrasing.

APPLICATION IN DIFFERENT STYLES

- **Blues:** Target the flat third or fifth to add a bluesy feel.
- **Rock:** Emphasise power chord tones (root and fifth) for strong, driving melodies.
- **Jazz:** Focus on extensions like the seventh or ninth for a more sophisticated sound.
- **Metal:** Use arpeggios to target chord tones within fast, technical solos.

Final Thoughts

Targeting chord tones is a cornerstone of melodic playing. By mastering this skill, you'll develop a deeper connection to the harmony and open up a world of expressive possibilities. Take your time to integrate these techniques into your practice and watch your playing transform.

Peace,

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